

TAKING CHARGE
CM Naveen Patnaik during the inauguration of a hospital in Bhubaneswar last month; his aide V.K. Pandian is seated behind

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BACK IN THE FIGHT

Following failed alliance talks, the BJD strategically selects candidates to challenge BJP's nominees, marking the onset of an electoral showdown

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

on X: "The BJD will contest in all 147 assembly and all 21 Lok Sabha constituencies with the support of the people of Odisha and win more than three-fourth seats under the leadership of Shri Naveen Patnaik." These announcements ended the biggest political suspense in Odisha's recent political history.

Samal, in his post, highlighted Odisha's *asmita* (pride) as a major poll plank. The party plans to target Patnaik's close aide and chairman of the government's 5T (Transformational Initiatives) and Nabin Odisha campaigns, V.K. Pandian. The Tamil Nadu-born former IAS officer runs the show in the government as well as the party. Sources say despite the BJD's development work, there is an undercurrent of disgruntlement among the people who do not wish to see a non-Odia at the helm of affairs. "We believe that it was Pandian's idea to form a pact with us to legitimise and solidify his position in the state," says a BJP source. According to sources, the alliance primarily fell through owing to the BJP's demand that it join the new government post the election. The BJD leadership was against the idea since it is confident of securing a majority on its own. Following initial talks, it was decided that the BJD would contest 107 seats and leave 40 for the BJP. For the Lok Sabha, the BJD was willing to let go 11 for the BJP. On the other hand, BJP sources claim that their internal surveys projected a significantly higher number of assembly seats than the promised 40. Currently, it holds 23 MLAs compared to the BJD's 109. In 2019, the BJP secured eight Lok Sabha seats while the BJD claimed 12. On March 24, it finally released a list of 18 candidates for the Lok Sabha polls.

Many believe the "unnatural alliance" could have harmed Patnaik's secular credentials. The BJD had walked out of the BJP-led NDA ahead of the 2009 election following the 2007-2008 Hindu-Christian riots in Kandhamal district. Despite Odisha's population being predominantly Hindu (nearly 94 per cent), the state government's transformational initiatives have included the redevelopment of religious sites across all faiths. Moreover, BJD leaders argue that Odisha has undergone significant development, making an alliance unnecessary in their view. "We are confident that we will add to our previous tally," BJD Rajya Sabha MP Mujibulla Khan tells INDIA TODAY. "Development will be our poll plank." From friends to foes... to foes again, the battle lines seem drawn and visible. ■